AMSTERDAM, NETHERLANDS

Rijksmuseum: Masterpieces

Militia companies, domestic workers and passing pedestrians claim attention in different ways.



In *The Night Watch*, a commissioned company becomes a crowded event. In *The Milkmaid*, one domestic worker gives sustained attention to a narrow stream of milk. Neither picture distributes its emphasis democratically: light, scale and placement determine what becomes legible first. Their differences make a useful starting point for this selection.

Public portraits advertise status through dress and bodily presence. Household scenes assign importance to an activity or a small conflict; a late street view allows a passer-by to obstruct the city behind her. Follow who commands a space, who works within it, and whose actions are being watched. The answers are more specific than a general contrast between grandeur and everyday life.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/rijksmuseum

The selection · 20

1. The Night Watch
   Rembrandt van Rijn · 1642
2. The Milkmaid
   Johannes Vermeer · c. 1660
3. The Syndics
   Rembrandt van Rijn · 1662
4. The Little Street
   Johannes Vermeer · c. 1658
5. Woman in Blue Reading a Letter
   Johannes Vermeer · c. 1663
6. The Threatened Swan
   Jan Asselijn · c. 1650
7. The Merry Family
   Jan Steen · 1668
8. The Feast of Saint Nicholas
   Jan Steen · 1665 - 1668
9. Oopjen Coppit
   Rembrandt van Rijn · 1634
10. Marten Soolmans
    Rembrandt van Rijn · 1634
11. Enjoying the Ice near a Town
    Hendrick Avercamp · c. 1620
12. Portrait of a Married Couple, Probably Isaac Massa and Beatrix van der Laen
    Frans Hals · c. 1622
13. The Militia Company of Captain Reynier Reael
    Pieter Codde; Frans Hals · 1637
14. Children Teaching a Cat to Dance
    Jan Steen · 1660 - 1679
15. Portrait of an Old Lady, Possibly Elisabeth Bas
    Attributed to Ferdinand Bol · c. 1640–c. 1645
16. Self-Portrait as the Apostle Paul
    Rembrandt van Rijn · 1661
17. The Singel Bridge near the Paleisstraat, Amsterdam
    George Hendrik Breitner · 1896
18. Still Life with Flowers in a Glass Vase
    Jan Davidsz. de Heem · 1650 - 1683
19. Winter Landscape
    Jacob van Ruisdael · c. 1665
20. The Armourer
    Gabriël Metsu · c.1650 - c. 1660

01 / 20

The Night Watch

Rembrandt van Rijn

1642 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Rembrandt van Rijn. Officers and other civic guardsmen of District II in Amsterdam, under the command of Captain Frans Banninck Cocq and Lieutenant Willem van Ruytenburch, known as 'The Night Watch'. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The advancing captain and lieutenant give the company a direction, but the surrounding hands and weapons create competing movements. Rembrandt uses unequal illumination to distinguish actions within the crowd. The result does not resemble a lineup in which every sitter receives the same space. A corporate identity has to hold together through bodies doing different things.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-C-5

02 / 20

The Milkmaid

Johannes Vermeer

c. 1660 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Johannes Vermeer. The Milkmaid. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The stream of milk is small enough to miss in a hurried glance, yet the woman's pose is organised around sustaining it. Bread, basket and tabletop give the task a material setting. Vermeer keeps the wall comparatively empty so that concentration has little competition. Activity can be the centre of a picture without producing a large visible disturbance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-A-2344

03 / 20

The Syndics

Rembrandt van Rijn

1662 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Rembrandt van Rijn. The Sampling Officials of the Amsterdam Drapers' Guild, known as 'The Syndics'. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Several men direct attention outwards, making the viewer's position seem relevant to the business at the table. Their postures differ enough to suggest an interruption rather than a synchronised pose. Rembrandt holds the official group together while leaving its responses unequal. Public authority appears here as a working relationship among people, not simply a row of distinguished faces.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-C-6

04 / 20

The Little Street

Johannes Vermeer

c. 1658 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Johannes Vermeer. Gezicht op huizen in Delft, bekend als ‘Het straatje’. Image credit: Johannes Vermeer; Source credit: Google Arts & Culture — YAGJRuPz8yVuRQ. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The façade occupies far more space than the people using its doors and passage. Repairs interrupt the brickwork's regularity, giving the building a history of wear without requiring a dramatic story. Vermeer makes architecture and domestic activity operate at different scales. The small figures confirm use; the wall retains an attention of its own.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-A-2860

05 / 20

Woman in Blue Reading a Letter

Johannes Vermeer

c. 1663 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Johannes Vermeer. Woman in Blue Reading a Letter. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The letter is visible as an object but unavailable as information. Vermeer directs attention to the reader's absorption rather than supplying the message that causes it. The wall map extends the room's references to a larger world, yet it cannot resolve the contents either. The picture makes private attention accessible while preserving the privacy of what is read.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-C-251

06 / 20

The Threatened Swan

Jan Asselijn

c. 1650 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Jan Asselijn. De bedreigde zwaan. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The dog's approach gives the spread wings and extended neck an immediate cause. Asselijn makes the bright body a large, forceful shape against the dark water, while the nest explains what is being defended. Before pursuing symbolic readings, the encounter is already intelligible as a relation among an intruder, a vulnerable place and a resisting animal.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-A-4

07 / 20

The Merry Family

Jan Steen

1668 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Jan Steen. Het vrolijke huisgezin. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Music and drinking travel across generations around the table. Steen gives the children versions of the adults' behaviour, so the scene's pleasure also becomes a picture of example and imitation. Scattered objects keep the activity from staying neatly contained. The household entertains itself while exposing the habits through which its younger members are learning to participate.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-C-229

08 / 20

The Feast of Saint Nicholas

Jan Steen

1665 - 1668 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Jan Steen. Het Sint-Nicolaasfeest. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The celebration does not feel the same to every child. Gifts prompt satisfaction in one place and disappointment in another, while the adults watch the uneven results. Steen lets several small dramas coexist rather than selecting a single representative mood. The room holds a common occasion whose pleasures and frustrations remain individually distributed.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-A-385

09 / 20

Oopjen Coppit

Rembrandt van Rijn

1634 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Rembrandt van Rijn. Portrait of Oopjen Coppit. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The full-length format gives Oopjen room to stand as a complete bodily presence, not merely a face emerging from dress. Collar and cuffs draw bright boundaries within the dark costume; quieter changes of light distinguish its costly surfaces. Rembrandt makes restraint itself part of the display. Compare the more outward assertion of Marten's stance in the companion portrait.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-C-1768

10 / 20

Marten Soolmans

Rembrandt van Rijn

1634 · Rijksmuseum



Rembrandt van Rijn. Portrait of Marten Soolmans. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The bent arm widens Marten's outline, while pale stockings and elaborate shoe ornaments keep attention moving down the full figure. Dress is doing public work here. Seen with Oopjen, the portrait makes a pair without reducing either sitter to an accessory of the other. Shared scale and separate poses establish both connection and individual social presence.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-A-5033

11 / 20

Enjoying the Ice near a Town

Hendrick Avercamp

c. 1620 · Oil, wood and textile · Rijksmuseum



Hendrick Avercamp. Enjoying the Ice near a Town. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The ice allows many activities to occupy one continuous surface. Avercamp differentiates the small groups through posture and spacing, then lets the pale distance gradually absorb them. The scene rewards local inspection without requiring every incident to become the centre. Winter provides a shared public space, while each cluster finds a different way of using it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-C-1705

12 / 20

Portrait of a Married Couple, Probably Isaac Massa and Beatrix van der Laen

Frans Hals

c. 1622 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Frans Hals. Portrait of a Married Couple, Likely Isaac Abrahamsz Massa and Beatrix van der Laen. Image credit: Frans Hals; Source credit: Google Arts & Culture — TQGvNkNZ3MM17g. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The sitters lean into a close, comparatively relaxed arrangement beneath the foliage. Hals presents marriage through proximity and smiling address rather than two fully separate public poses. Their proposed identities remain uncertain; the visual relationship does not. The picture offers grounds for discussing the ease of this representation, not for reconstructing the couple's entire private life.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-A-133

13 / 20

The Militia Company of Captain Reynier Reael

Pieter Codde; Frans Hals

1637 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Pieter Codde; Frans Hals. Native museum collection image; source designation: Public Domain Mark 1.0. Rijksmuseum. Full source frame preserved; proportionally resized and JPEG compressed. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The wide formation has to accommodate individual sitters and a company identity at once. Sashes, weapons, the standard and changes of stance interrupt what could become an unbroken row. In the painting by Hals and Codde, variation gives the group its rhythm. Compare *The Night Watch*, where collective presence is organised more conspicuously as an unfolding event.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-C-374

14 / 20

Children Teaching a Cat to Dance

Jan Steen

1660 - 1679 · Oil on panel · Rijksmuseum



Jan Steen. Children Teaching a Cat to Dance, Known as The Dancing Lesson. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The children converge on an animal that has not chosen to perform. Steen lets the gap between their game and the cat's predicament carry the comedy, with the dog adding another response below. The scene is lively, but liveliness is not its only subject. It also shows how pleasure can depend on failing to recognise another creature's resistance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-A-718

15 / 20

Portrait of an Old Lady, Possibly Elisabeth Bas

Attributed to Ferdinand Bol

c. 1640–c. 1645 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Ferdinand Bol. Portrait of Elisabeth Jacobsdr. Bas. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/ferdinand-bol/portrait-of-elisabeth-jacobsdr-bas-1645 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Joined hands provide a second centre beneath the face, while the white collar separates both from the dark dress. The Rijksmuseum qualifies the sitter's identification and attributes the painting to Ferdinand Bol. Those uncertainties should remain visible in its label. They do not diminish the precision with which stillness, age and the formal seated pose establish a presence.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Self-Portrait as the Apostle Paul

Rembrandt van Rijn

1661 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Rembrandt van Rijn. Self Portrait as the Apostle Paul. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Rembrandt's face remains a likeness even while the book and wrapped head covering place it within a religious role. The image asks for two kinds of recognition at once: a particular painter and an imagined apostle. Its dark surroundings keep those identities concentrated in the same figure. Self-portraiture here includes the deliberate act of becoming someone else.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-A-4050

17 / 20

The Singel Bridge near the Paleisstraat, Amsterdam

George Hendrik Breitner

1896 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



George Hendrik Breitner. Native museum collection image; source designation: Public Domain Mark 1.0. Rijksmuseum. Full source frame preserved; proportionally resized and JPEG compressed. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The foreground pedestrian comes too close to remain a small ornament within a city view. Her scale and cropping interrupt the prospect of bridge and buildings. Breitner makes the street an encounter with other moving people rather than an unobstructed architectural scene. The snowy setting stays recognisable, but the passer-by claims the immediate space.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-A-3580

18 / 20

Still Life with Flowers in a Glass Vase

Jan Davidsz. de Heem

1650 - 1683 · Rijksmuseum



Jan Davidsz. de Heem. Still Life with Flowers in a Glass Vase. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The flowers crowd the vase without losing their differences of colour, shape and direction. Curling stems and insects complicate its perimeter, preventing a clean division between bouquet and empty ground. De Heem makes close inspection compatible with an abundant whole. No single blossom has to dominate for the arrangement to hold together.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-C-214

19 / 20

Winter Landscape

Jacob van Ruisdael

c. 1665 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Jacob van Ruisdael. Winter Landscape. Rijksmuseum. Public Domain Mark 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Snow receives the limited light that the heavy clouds permit. Ruisdael makes the narrow opening in the sky consequential because the rest of the scene is so subdued. The small figures do not turn the weather into background for a story. Their presence instead provides a human measure within conditions larger than their immediate activities.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: SK-A-349

20 / 20

The Armourer

Gabriël Metsu

c.1650 - c. 1660 · Oil on canvas · Rijksmuseum



Gabriël Metsu. The Armorer. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/gabriel-metsu/the-armorer · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The two workers occupy different positions around equipment that partly fills the dark room. A small hot glow makes the task's centre legible amid tools and metal. Metsu describes work as a relationship between bodies, materials and a usable place. The workshop's clutter has a purpose even where individual objects remain difficult to separate.

Object source · Open artwork

Compare the public and private pose

Set one full-length portrait beside a worker or reader and ask how much space the figure occupies, and why. This selection concerns collection holdings, including works whose display arrangements can change. Check current object and visiting information; the sequence here is an argument for looking, not a guaranteed walking route.

Further reading

Dutch Paintings in The Metropolitan Museum of Art, Volumes I and II

Walter Liedtke · Read online or download · English

Walter Liedtke's two-volume Dutch Paintings in The Metropolitan Museum of Art offers detailed entries on many of the artists represented here. Its object studies help explain the differences between a group portrait, a domestic scene and a still life.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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